that India was a passive player with regards to America's intervention in Afghanistan. I just couldn't believe that there wasn't that much strategic consultation and interaction between India and the US on Afghanistan. In fact, I was the one who facilitated the first trilateral engagement between the three countries [in 2012] and I realised in that meeting how distant the two countries were.'[13]

The changing Western approach towards Afghanistan impacted India's foreign policy calculus. As the previous two chapters showed, India had increased its support for Karzai and began appreciating differences between the various Taliban factions and the complex nature of their relationship with Pakistan. This policy learning was as much an outcome of India's own desire to better understand Afghanistan's internal dynamics, as much it was steered by the realisation that the West lacked the political will to counter the Taliban on a long term basis. A decisive shift towards reconciliation at the 2010 London conference merely confirmed what India feared the most, which was a format of talks that could give Pakistan strategic leeway to set the terms of talks (one of which was reduced Indian presence in Afghanistan). As this chapter shows, immediately after the London conference, India began hectic behind-the-scenes lobbying with various Afghan, regional, and international stakeholders to steer the reconciliation initiative away from Pakistan. Quickly adjusting to the fact that talks with the Afghan Taliban was inevitable, India signed the Strategic Partnership Agreement with Kabul in October 2011 and endorsed an Afghan-led reconciliation. New Delhi's conciliatory policy shift, led by Manmohan Singh, Menon, and Lambah, thus, was an exercise to dilute the so-called 'Western model' of reconciliation, and to make it an Afghan-owned enterprise, however difficult it may be.[14]

India's statements at the UN reflected its changing stance on reconciliation. From blaming the UN for not terming all Afghan militants as 'terrorists', India developed a nuanced terminology of whom to blame and how when debating the Afghan situation at the UN. It eventually accepted that the Afghan Taliban were not terrorists even if they were not to be valued at par with the Afghan government. Evolving regional advocacies by China, Russia, and Iran also pushed India into adopting a conciliatory stand. Worried about a spillover of Islamist